

Family/Friends Support Guide: Through Those 8 weeks



As the days go by with the physical and mental training being increased daily, your recruits are feeling the pressure. The process is firmly in place now and they will not be asked to do anything they are not capable of. They are knee deep with intense training, military protocol, the expectations that their CC's (Company Commanders) and everything that the USCG has for them. They know exactly what is required of them and what will happen if they fail.

Letters are going to be the main source of communication as they are going through this rigorous training, and they will create some stability. Keep your letters going, constantly! Short letters that can be read quickly. Motivational quotes, bible verses. Whatever will keep them focused on the next. Help them remember to always reach just beyond what they think they can do. With every reach they get stronger, and their confidence grows.

We cannot stress enough, if you get a letter from your recruit saying they have received no mail, that is normal. Many times, they have written to you saying they have not had mail and the very next day they receive every letter you have ever written. It is quite common for letters to crisscross through the mail process. It does not make it easier to read, they are not receiving your mail, but at least you know it is just the mail moving slowly.

Mailing Address

SR (Last Name, First, MI)

(Company Name)

Coast Guard Training Center Cape May
1 Munro Avenue
Cape May, NJ 08204

IT IS NOT NECESSARY TO INCLUDE THE NAME OF THE HALL IN THE ADDRESS! The format is not as important as making sure the recruit's name and the company name is in the address. **They will begin receiving mail on Wednesday of week 02** and get 20 minutes of mail time that day. After that, they have 5 minutes a day before taps except on Sundays. Keep in mind that mail moves very slowly once it reaches the base. Cape May not only houses TRACEN, but many other operational CG groups.

Now that we have squared away the mailing situation, we have provided some general definitions that the recruits will frequently hear in bootcamp. Don't be alarmed, just know these are some tools that are used to address any deficiency that is required to graduate. Also remember other phrases to embrace; *no news is good news - need to know - patience - trust the process*. They will come in handy while you are anticipating hearing from them each week.

Reverted - Being reverted is generally for discipline issues that go beyond simply failing a test. If a recruit is continuously disrespectful or has a bad attitude they can be reverted to the next company. They are not reverted because there are too many recruits in a company or "just because." There are specific reasons, and everything is documented. If

your recruit is reverted, they will be required to call you, it's policy. It will be emotional. They could be deflated, crying, and worried you are disappointed. Encourage them, tell them you love them and they can push through.

Rephased - Bootcamp is designed to be stressful on the body and mind. Sometimes a recruit will get too sick to train, get injured or needs extra work to catch up. Therefore, their training is simply delayed. If they are injured/sick and cannot continue training, they will be rephased (delayed) until they are healed and cleared by the medical staff. Once the medical staff has cleared them to continue training, they will join the company that is in the same week they were in when they were pulled (temporarily) from training. For extra work, that translates to extra help physically or academically. If your recruit is rephased, they are required to call you. The call might be emotional. They might be frustrated, crying and worried about their future success as a recruit. Encourage them, tell them you love them and they can push through.

Incentive Training (IT) - EVERY recruit goes through this. They may not be pulling together as a team. They may keep making the same mistake over and over. They are not keeping their racks squared away, or simply not coming together. When one is in trouble, they are all in trouble. This is the "one for all and all for one" mentality that is needed from every USCG member.

Eventually, they will be held accountable for repeated individual mistakes.

Recruit Motivation Program (RAMP) – "One More Chance" - Think offenses that could meet the level of a reversion, but the CC's are attempting to use a life line to keep that recruit in the same week of training. RAMP provides recruits with extra training and mentoring. Contrary to widespread belief, it is not where they abuse recruits, they are not sent there on a whim, and it is definitely not a place they go so they can be ridiculed. All of those are absolutely urban myths!

Now that everyone has taken a big gulp and let reality set in for a bit, take note . . .

- Recruits are not expected to do anything they have not been instructed in or are not capable to complete.
- They have been given the expectations. They have been and will be taught to do them correctly. Now, they need to execute them in a timely manner to the standards of the USCG.
- The CC's are trained and extremely methodical in everything they do with regulations they must follow.

Can you feel the preparation for the next, next? It will constantly be happening; your recruit will always be preparing for the next, next. When they get to the fleet, they should always be preparing for their USCG career. Bootcamp expectations are constantly being raised because your recruits are getting stronger and can handle it. If

you receive one of these unexpected calls remember, they are emotional but that is normal. They are questioning their abilities and their reason for volunteering. It is all part of the process and your job is to encourage them forward. Remind them one the reasons why they wanted to join.

You know your recruit; you know their strengths and you know what they need to hear to keep pushing forward. Affirm your love and push them forward, say those words, a lot! When you hang up, then you can fall apart. You know where to turn for help! You have an entire group ready to pick you up and encourage you.

Trust the process. Things will fall into place when they need to for each person, on both sides of the fence.

The 1st week is almost over ...

They will endure several days of medical screenings and be poked, prodded, given immunizations, dental exams (some may require having wisdom teeth pulled sometime during bootcamp), eye exams, and for the male recruits - haircuts. For the females they are taught how to put their hair in that tight bun with no strays flying around. On Friday they will meet their Company Commanders (CC's) for the first time. It is a long and stressful weekend for the recruits. You may begin writing letters or cards to your recruit as soon as they ship. On Sunday from 0800 to 1300, recruits have Divine Hours. During this time, they may attend church services and write letters home. This time is also used for ironing uniforms, shining boon dockers, studying, and many other tasks they need to catch up on. Time management is their focus now, there is always a reason for what they do or do not do. So don't be surprised If you don't receive many letters back.

There is an outline and rules/regulations the CC's must follow so your recruits will have the foundation needed for the fleet, plus rules/regulations they must follow for

everyone's safety. They are being trained, they are being fed, they are being provided with time to sleep and taken care of medically. All while being paid and earning vacation time!

The first weekend seems like the longest and hardest; the weekdays keep you busy with work, school, chores, etc. Whatever the reason, the first weekend could mean you are at a loss because there is a huge chunk of time that you do not know how to fill or even have the desire to fill! Do not despair, everything will get figured out and you will realize, you can do this, and you can fill your time and you can come to terms with this life and even have fun with it. Just as the recruits are learning to cope and move forward step by step, you will as well. Be patient with yourself, the process and each other. Learning and trusting the process will look and feel different for everyone, but this road you are on is leading everyone to the final day of boot camp.

Week 02 Trust the process

You DID it ...

Bet you never thought you would be glad to say good-bye to a weekend! Looks better than the tangled mess of emotions you saw and felt last week, doesn't it? The emotions might still be a tangled mess, but your recruits have worked through the hardest weekend of bootcamp and will continue to follow the course that has been planned for them. With another week comes another phrase for families to grab onto. Do you feel like you are always holding your breath?

Trying to stay "in the loop" but not really understanding where or what your loop is? This phrase might help or at least explain.

Trying to move into new routines is challenging, knowing the routines are changing week to week adds a different twist to things. Knowing and accepting the rearrangement in your life can be beyond challenging. There is a process for both sides of the recruit experience and if you are willing to follow and accept it (to the best of your ability), you will begin to understand everything has a reason. You will see the process is beginning to work through the letters you receive and eventually you will appreciate it and your

recruit will be thankful for it. You might even begin to trust it. For some, the first few weeks of letters you will be receiving will bring additional worries because your recruit will be sharing emotions and hardships like they have never seen or experienced before. For those that understand the why behind the necessary, it will tell you all is well. You know and understand the process but not everyone does. Embracing challenges and learning new routines is not a bad thing. It is an important thing and your recruit will be excited for you when they realize you are focused on your growth through this as well. Set goals for yourself and share them with your recruit - we have seen family members commit to eating healthier, running a certain number of miles, hiking or biking trails weekly, so many goals you can set for yourself! Share a few with other members of the group if you like.

You never know, you might just challenge each other to a virtual run or something similar for your recruits! That would give them something to talk about for sure. One group of families challenged everyone (who wanted to) to run/bike/walk 4 miles every day! Their recruits had no words except to be excited their families were connecting in the outside world.

Week 03 Changes in Attitudes . . .

Wouldn't it be great if we could tell you this is the week you will stop, "forever holding your breath and willing each day to pass quickly"?! We cannot tell you that, we can tell you they are preparing for their next, "next". Whatever that might be. They have their expectations and are still missing them BUT they are training daily and applying what they learn. Each day they are preparing for bootcamp's version of "everything in its place and a place for everything". Which is, "everything for a reason and that reason will be known when you need it".

For those at home, who know the process, it might be unsettling from this viewpoint, but you know what is expected - how it will happen and why it must be this way. For those that have no clue what the process is - it definitely feels unsettling, and you are trying to trust the process.

- 1) Recruits are in bed at 9:30PM every night. Even weekends. When is the last time you could say that about your recruit?
- 2) You know where they are 24 hours a day. Somewhere on the base, in Cape May, your

recruits are working hard. In class, marching, in the gym or pool, doing physical fitness, whatever - you know where they are during bootcamp. I am guessing you could not say that about your recruit prior to bootcamp.

3) They eat three square a day. Breakfast, lunch, and dinner. Every day. Without fail and they are required to eat. So, no grabbing an apple and go kind of lunch. Plus, they get chewy granola bars before bedtime. (a much-requested item after bootcamp at that!)

4) They have constant "chaperones". Constant. More than one. Usually several at a time and sometimes a whole bunch at once! And these chaperones really do care about your recruit. They WANT them to succeed so much they are in their face every day to make sure they do succeed.

5) They are getting exercise every single day. Many times, a day.

6) Your recruit is NOT drinking alcohol or smoking cigarettes or any other funny kind of plant. None. Not at all. No worries or wondering if they made it home last night or who they were with.

7) They are making some great, lifelong friends who, (are you ready for this) have goals, dreams, and ambition. The same goals, dreams, and ambition as your recruit AND instead of negative peer pressure your recruit is being encouraged every day by those shipmates.

8) They need your encouraging letters! Not sad news, not news to worry about or news that you are worried for them. At this point, they might be worried about them.

Please, please, please, do not call the base. Do not email. No matter how tempted you may be. They cannot and will not give information on specific recruits.

Calling the base repeatedly or emailing them is not going to change that. Imagine how horrified your recruit will be when the command comes to them and asks them to write a letter home to tell their parents NOT to call the base. They will never live it down in bootcamp. NO ONE wants to be that recruit. This is the time for you to learn to let go and trust that your recruit is good to go. They have chosen a career of saving the lives of others and putting others before themselves. You obviously did something right. Do not hinder their career by being the hovering parent. Breathe in, breathe out! If anything goes wrong that you need to know about, you will get a phone call. Relax, and embrace the upcoming weeks. The CG has been doing this an exceptionally long time. Nothing your recruit goes through is new. No reaction your recruit has, is new. The CG has seen it all. Trust the process.

On another note, many of you have not received any mail from your Coastie yet. This is very normal, especially for week 3. Bootcamp is not like anything else they have ever

done. There are no “relaxed” breaks. They cannot write a quick note during lunch or during a bathroom break. They train from 0530 to 2130 every single day. They break for meals, water intake and the bathroom, that is it. Sunday divine hours’ time is used for studying, uniform maintenance, polishing boots, additional duties, studying, etc. Just keep writing. They need to hear from you much more than you need to hear from them. Tell them you are proud of them, and you believe in them, and you know they can do this. Do not forget - the first letter you receive could be very rough to read! Keep in mind, what they wrote about has passed, they have moved on. If you must reference what they were feeling, simply remind them they moved on then, they can move on now.

Week 04- Dream Time

Can you believe it, Week 04? Your recruits are tired, but realize they are doing this! It is not the physical side that wears them down, it is the mental and emotional. They are realizing just how important home is and how important their families are to them, many (most) are homesick.

Bootcamp is its own, stressful, one-of-a-kind world. They will work through it of course, but it can be overwhelming. They need your letters and encouragement. Be sure to tell them you believe in them and their determination to get through this in every letter. Remind them that this is the halfway point and send a funny picture with a halfway point sign from the family pet or friends! Get creative with it. Humor really is the best medicine.

This week they will fill out their Assignment Data Card, lovingly referred to as dream sheets. On the dream sheets they will list their top three choices for where they hope to be stationed when they graduate from bootcamp and what job they would prefer Fireman or Seaman. They list which is more important to them, job, or location.

- Do not be surprised if they choose something far from home, or some place you haven't discussed. Have you ever heard of places like Owensboro, KY or Omaha,

NE. Yes, the USCG is represented in those areas!

- The recruits receive constant information from their CC's and their mentors about stations, ratings, duties, large cutters vs. small cutters vs. station life. They are learning sometimes those out of the way, rarely heard about assignments, are many times diamonds in hiding.

If they hope to get Texas and end up in Iowa do not be surprised. Both locations are in the same, exceptionally large district! Also understand that for some the location does not matter - they listed the job as more important. (Seaman, above deck - Fireman, below deck)

The Coast Guard tries to fill their requests, but the needs of the fleet are always filled first. Perspective and a willingness to adapt to whatever comes their way is a huge part to being a successful Coastie. No matter how long that career is.

Week 05 Assignment Time

At the end of the week your recruit will find out their next duty station. Recruits are normally given a 3-5-minute phone call to tell their loved ones about their new assignment and whether they are on track to graduate on time. These phone calls are very formal and noisy.

There will be CC's in the background doing a lot of training, and can be a loud environment. Your recruit will use a lot of Sir's/Ma'ams and may not sound like themselves. These phone calls can happen any time after the recruits are given their orders but typically do not start until Friday night or Saturday and can go into the following week depending upon the size of the company. The calls are random with no specific order, if you miss a call, DO NOT try to call back. Your recruit will be given another opportunity to reach you. Be sure to note what city, which cutter, air station, small boat station, or sector your recruit tells you. Some recruits choose not to call home and instead wait until they are on their liberty times when they can talk more relaxed. DO NOT call their new unit on their behalf. All communication to new unit must come from the recruit. I know, it's tempting, you have questions, but this is their time to make a first impression.

Sunday's might also mean an off-base run for each company depending on weather and what week of training they are in. During week five, a company may receive their "Colors", This refers to the company flag, it will be the actual signal flag for the corresponding letter of their company. In the early weeks, the company carries a generic white flag with the corresponding company letter on it. Once the lead company commander feels they have earned the right to bear their company flag, it will be awarded. This usually happens in weeks 5, 6, or 7 and is one of the highlights of every recruit.

Week 06 More Changes . . .

Your recruits have accomplished a lot, more than you or they could have imagined when they arrived at Cape May! You are absolutely seeing and hearing changes now. Your recruits are now moving along, understanding challenging work is necessary but with it brings a certain amount of pride in getting things accomplished. Not only getting them accomplished but doing it well. Taking pride in knowing because they are willing to put in the blood, sweat and tears. The finished product will be amazing and withstand all kinds of pressures.

Letters are a bit more encouraging now, you are hearing a new confidence in them, and you know things are falling into place. You trusted and now you know, the next step for your soon-to-be recruit is firmly in place. There are new goals, they are reaching new heights. They sounded hoarse, tired, a bit more grown up during the assignment calls, but they delivered news that is going to change their life and by default, yours. Even if the news is not what they expected (or you wanted) every assignment will be what your soon to be Coastie makes it. They have learned through their training that they will not like everything they experience, but the experience will give them important lessons toward their future. Every person, every mission, every cutter, and every station will have a vital role to play in what the USCG accomplishes every day. There are no small

roles.

Once the assignment call comes through, you find yourself once again waiting for another with more information. Housing, travel, there are even more questions now. Every process takes time, every process will help you develop patience. You will begin to see a routine develop with all things military/government related.

They know family and friends are encouraging them as well, which is a great thing. For those at home, there has been a shift; you are waiting for news of training, but also waiting for news about the next assignment. For those who know what happens next, you understand the process, while familiar, is full of stress and at times seems impossible. For those that are unfamiliar with the process, you are feeling the stress and pressure of not knowing.

A suggestion, in your searching and wondering how all this is going to fit together and work, stop and ponder a few often-forgotten realities:

- The USCG is investing vast amounts of knowledge, experience, and money into your Coastie. They will not let them sleep under a bridge and will make sure they have all the tools to succeed. There are safeguards and programs to help with every possible issue. It will of course, depend on your future Coastie leaning on their command and asking them for help if necessary. They can and should ask questions to their command if they are confused or stuck. Help is always there, just ask.
- Every single person at the next command has been in the same spot as your future Coastie. Brand new, fresh out of boot camp, nervous, scared and not wanting to make it obvious they are brand new, fresh out of bootcamp. Guess what? Everyone will know your reporting Coastie is brand new and reporting fresh out of boot camp. They will expect them to need help, but they will also expect them to ask. There is a reason they are learning, "nothing is given - it's earned". They earn the respect of their fellow Coasties when they prove they can stand on their own, ask their own questions instead of waiting on others to show and/or tell them. Everything will fall into place. Another common occurrence with transfers, they never happen the way they are planned or without a few hiccups. I can testify to that personally – multiple times!

It might not help calm your nerves and you may be feeling very anxiousness about all this. The hope is you can take a deep breath and realize more calls will come when they have more information and this part of USCG life is always stressful, no matter how many years or months have passed. PCS (Permanent Change of Station) will always be around and will always be stressful. Not as stressful as right now, because the lack of communication creates the biggest stressor. It is one of the special times that just

uttering the letters “PCS” will create a certain anxiousness and camaraderie among Coasties. Everyone has a PCS story or will have a PCS story eventually.

It seems to be a rite of passage; you are just going to push through and hope for the best! Everyone wants to share their "nightmare PCS stories" but they forget the successful ones and there are many of those as well.

Take a deep breath and know when your recruit has information to share and the training schedule allows, they will call. If the call does not happen until the liberty call - it does not mean anything is wrong, it simply means they have no information to relay. Trust the process; need to know, patience and no news is good news are even more important to remember right now.

Liberty, liberty, liberty . . .

Translated for those at home - calls home! Lots of them, for hours. Face Time, texts, pictures, and stories. How does that sound for your Saturday plans? You can celebrate with your recruit what they have accomplished so far and what they hope to accomplish in the future.

Once the liberty call goes out, they will head to the CG Exchange first, to get all kinds of yummy snacks and beverages, that up to this point, were off limits. Not surprisingly, the decision is quite difficult and can be a lengthy process after weeks of being told what to do and say! Some select one or two items; others fill their basket. It can be quite a conundrum to decide. Then, it is to the Harborview All Hands Club where they will begin relaxing, making phone calls and later (or now and later) they will order some food from the menu. They will have the same view for liberty that you will during the Meet and Greet Thursday before graduation!

Are you finding it a little bit unbelievable that at this time tomorrow you will have talked with, laughed with, and had eyes on your recruit!? A process that seemed to loom forever in the beginning has picked up a little speed. Enjoy it today because at the end of liberty, it will be back to the grind for everyone.

When the calls come, there will be smiles, laughter, tears and an unbelievable sense of accomplishment and pride in what they have done up to this point. Stories will abound of their accomplishments, their vision of the past and hopes for the future. You will hear the laughter and antics of their company, through your recruit's eyes and the eyes of their friends. The determination and focus on their voices and faces will have you catching your breath in amazement.

Parents - This will be the first phone call that you can reconnect and realize that although there are miles between your son/daughter – they will always be near – they

are in your heart and you in theirs. **They now understand that everything you taught them was to bring them to this point in their life.** To head out on their own, knowing you will always be their biggest cheerleader. They realize you will always be there when they want to share a success, vent, cry or simply need some “parental wisdom” to hear, not necessarily follow, but to hear it. So today, let them do all of that while you sit back and share time and some snacks with them. Relax and enjoy this time because it will go fast.

Spouses - Are you all tingly with anticipation? Wanting everything to look put together as if you are in total control of everything? That will happen every single time your spouse comes home from being away. Every. Single. Time. Guess what, your spouse will not care – they want to see YOU - whether you are a mess and barely hanging on or perfectly put together. Do not put added pressure on yourself when you are already feeling a teensy bit overwhelmed. They want to see you, share their stories with you and relax with you. They know you can handle this life, or they would not have taken it on. They fully understand the last weeks have not been easy, there have been difficult almost impossible times. Guess what – you both did it. You both moved through those times and today will prove that although distance does not necessarily make the heart fonder – it shows you can do this life together, even when you are apart. Enjoy liberty, enjoy the moments of quiet, the moments of laughter and the moments of being together even if it's through a phone call. What a day tomorrow will be!

What question will be asked first, what story will be told, what snacks will they have? You should have some snacks on hand, even having "their" snack on your end so you can have some laughs over your guess of what they will have. Your recruit will have changed, but they are still the same.

Week 07 Are we there yet ...

Remember that first weekend that went so slow for some? This past weekend went by crazy fast? Particularly, Saturday afternoon? So many good stories and great memories. Even though you were not physically together, you realized your recruits have indeed been taking steps towards their goal of becoming Coasties. There are still things to complete and pieces still need to be put into place, but they are almost there.

REWIND and REPEAT!

Liberty, liberty, liberty! At this point in training, liberty is a beautiful word! It is a day they have been working for because they know it is a day off and time to relax (a little bit) and have fun (mostly). Saturday will be especially fun as liberty will be off-base and for

most of the day. Only your recruits will know the exact time of liberty, but have no doubt they will contact you as soon as they are able! It usually begins around 9-10 AM and the texting or calls will begin after that.

The biggest question some have, can we spend the day with them? Not really. Now, the why of what some will think is a dumb or "insensitive" answer. If you are the lucky few who live close by, why not? Especially if your recruit requested it. Here is the thing, they are still in training so you need to consider things they might not be in their excitement. We get it, they want to see you - you want to see them, but if you have learned one thing so far, recruit training has a purpose and everything they are experiencing is intentional. They are becoming United States Coast Guardsmen. Even "relaxing for a day" will help them realize what they have decided to pour themselves into is not just about them or what they want. You may not understand it, you probably won't like it, but everything is there for a reason.

- They are still very much in recruit training. To the public, they are Coasties ready to have some down time and fun. Except the "fun" has limits, there are explicit rules and guidelines they will be expected to follow with harsh consequences if they do not. Including, staying in groups for the day.
- They will be wearing their dress uniform which means they will be very recognizable as a member of the United States Coast Guard and all the responsibilities that go along with that. They will be on stage for the world to see and judge. While the "rules" of military bearing are a bit relaxed during off-base liberty – the responsibility of wearing the uniform with dignity, honor and diligence to duty are firmly in place.
- Try not to call or text them before they call you. Because their phone might show that it is charging or on the move, it does not mean they are authorized to call, talk with or text you. They will text and call as soon as they can, remember last week, as soon as they could, they did. Cell phones are at the top of the list for a recruit spending extra time in recruit training at this point.

This will be the last opportunity for many of them to relax and have fun together without their CC's around and before they spread out all over the globe. Some will cross paths eventually or even at their first assignment, but not all. Would you really want to steal these last fun and relaxing moments from your recruit? This is their moment to begin the decompression from bootcamp. They will share dreams, talk about things that are making them nervous, and share all of that with you eventually. It is their time to simply enjoy things as they come. This day will also remind you, just as last week did. Just because you are not physically together, does not mean you are not together. If all you have to connect with is a phone call, that is better than nothing. Let them have this last

opportunity to catch up, laugh and talk leisurely with those in their company. Let them enjoy the public's reaction to them with each other. They will tell you about it when they can. This is their day to relax and have some fun with each other.

Cape May will treat them beautifully, let them soak it all in. They might even be treated to a drink or meal. They have worked hard for these moments - do not steal their thunder by having the attention taken off them by having someone say "you've raised a fine son/daughter" or "your spouse is doing a great thing", you will have all that in due time, let this day be all about them. Give them time to unwind and soak in the simple pleasure of leisurely walking around town. Finally without worrying whether they are in step, yelling loud enough or wondering who is watching ready to pounce. Let them just enjoy breathing deep, knowing they can do mostly what they want for a few hours. It is an intoxicating feeling after 7+ weeks of intense training, to once again be in a civilian world.

Most important of all ENJOY and relax with them. Enjoy every tiny second. Breathe it in and simply be. Do not think of tomorrow or tonight or even the next hour. Enjoy the tiny moments. Enjoy Cape May and the surrounding towns through their eyes. You have heard throughout bootcamp "focus on what is directly in front of you" - do not worry about what happens tomorrow. Those words are even more important when sharing liberty, even though it is a phone call not in person. Remember, this is your training as well and sometimes a phone call is all we get. You will begin to understand, once they get to their station a random call/txt or email is not so small after all and makes your day!

Week 08 is finally here!

What a ride this has been! Thankfully, this chapter will be over in a few days. It was a little tougher than you imagined. As excited as you are that it is over and you would not want it to be any longer than it needs to be - it comes with a bittersweetness as you realize not only is a chapter over, but this book is closed. Your recruit is now a Coastie with all the responsibilities that come with it including adulting!

Parenting was finished the moment your son/daughter began the trek to Cape May. It does not mean you are not their parent anymore, it simply means, with their forward steps - you've (hopefully) been learning to step aside and realize they are adults. They are responsible for their direction now. For the last 8 weeks, they have been learning they are capable of anything if they work hard and stay focused on what they want. They have landed in the "adult world" because you prepared them, they landed abruptly, but safely. It will be rocky at times, but that is okay. You have learned that while the

process is slow and at times painful, it is doable and your Coastie is ready to move on to the next chapter. Be proud and happy with every success and failure. Especially in failure because the lesson(s) learned will keep them moving forward with something to learn for the future. Quite often, their definition of success will not be yours and the definition of success changes with the situation. This is their life, their choices, and their success.



What have you learned, what is the takeaway for a parent beyond bootcamp?

- You have learned to keep yourself busy when you miss them. You are not the first, nor will you be the last parent to walk this path. It is not necessary to know what they are doing every minute of the day because they live in your heart. You have memories to think about while knowing there will be new memories to create and tuck away.
- You have learned, although you will always be their parent, more importantly you are their friend, and that friendship needs to be explored and embraced. It is an exciting new world and dimension to your relationship, have fun with it!
- You have learned, there are boundaries. While the USCG is receptive to parent involvement - there are limits. Learning those limits is a hard, sometimes slow process, but it is the most important process we need to continually develop. Do not push to be involved, let it progress naturally.

Make no mistake, you will still help them, guide them and share their victories as well as their defeats. The balance now is to let them show you what they have learned during this first chapter and encourage them to find the answers instead of giving them. They

should lean on their knowledge, the knowledge within the command and their mentors (mentors are not just for bootcamp) to lead them to the answers. They know what to do, sometimes they just need to be reminded. As much as it will hurt you to watch, sometimes they need to fail to remind them whose career it is, so they learn to take care of it. The amount of time they put into their career determines their success. Not how much time you put into it.

They entered USCG Recruit Training Center as individuals, they will leave as a member of the USCG ready to report to their next assignment. How incredible is that?

The moment that you have been waiting for, Graduation! "Reunited and it feels so good!". It will be worth the wait to see them in the uniform and the confidence to start their journey in the fleet. Please pay close attention to the guidelines for attending graduation and the ceremony rules. If you have any additional questions, please reach out to their recruiter.

Some things to know about accessing the base for graduation:

- You will need a government-issued photo ID to enter the base. Currently, the base can accept all state driver's licenses as well as state-issued non-driver IDs.
- Passports and pass cards are also acceptable forms of ID.
- Driver's licenses issued by Puerto Rico are in the system and accepted.
- If you are renewing your driver's license but don't have it in time for graduation, bring your expired license and proof of renewal. A paper license with your expired license is also acceptable. A photo student ID card is also acceptable as a second form of ID.
- Those attending graduation who are under the age of 18 do not need ID, but must be accompanied by an adult with ID.

There are no "tickets" to attend graduation, but your recruit will need to add your name to the guest list. They will call later in training to verify the names or give them the names during week 07 Liberty.

If you forget your photo ID, you will be turned away at the gate.

Ubers, taxis, etc., are not permitted to enter the base. You will need to be in your own private vehicle or rental car. If you use an Uber, taxi, etc., you will need to walk in from the front gate.

- **In case you missed it - there are no guest limits for the Graduation Ceremony, Meet and Greet Thursday Evening, or breakfast Friday Morning.** Your recruit will be calling to confirm the number of guests attending the Meet and Greet/Breakfast and the names of those attending graduation. *If you are not sure a family member/friend can attend, add their name. Better their name be on the list and not be able to attend than the other way around. You cannot surprise your recruit with a guest.*

1. You will be considered a guest of your recruit. Anything you do will reflect on

them; follow the rules and guidelines of the training center and it will be a momentous day for both you and your recruit.

2. The graduation ceremony is a formal military celebration, and your graduating recruits will be in their dress uniform. While the dress code does not call for tuxes and evening gowns, it is expected that you show your recruits the respect they have earned by dressing in business casual or Sunday best. Think about all the pictures you will be taking with your Coastie and their friends who will look amazing in their uniforms. *The Thursday night Meet and Greet is casual.
3. **Destination**, set your GPS for **1 Munro Avenue, Cape May NJ**. That will get you to the main gate, further instructions will be given with plenty of directions from there.
4. Signs and posters are fine for the graduation, make sure you do not block the view of those around you. Balloons are not as welcome, as they create havoc with our ecosystem and can get blown around quite a bit, creating distractions from the main event, your graduating recruits!❤️
5. Diaper bags are acceptable, camera bags and purses are not. As far as attire, please keep in mind:
 - It gets windy in Cape May, there have been some interesting and quite revealing situations created with short, frilly dresses that can be blown around or up. The wind can be brutal, layer your clothes.
 - You will be walking from place to place and sitting on bleachers. Comfortable shoes are advised. Watch the weather forecasts for appropriate attire. In the winter it is always breezy which makes it feel colder. For those that are active duty and want to wear your uniform, Service Dress Blues is the Uniform of the Day.

Enjoy planning and preparing for the ending of this great "adventure".



